

Elena Zhakov

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EDUCATION

Clark University

B.S. Biochemistry & Molecular Biology

M.S Biochemistry & Molecular Biology (4+1 Accelerated Program)

• Honors Programme for Undergraduates | **GPA: 3.94**

Relevant courses: Organic Chemistry, Biochemistry, Biophysical Chemistry, Calculus, Physics, Management, Funding Ventures,

Worcester, MA

September 2024 – May 2027

September 2027 – May 2028

United World Colleges Maastricht (UWC)

International Baccalaureate Diploma Program (IBDP)

Maastricht, Netherlands

September 2022 - April 2024

WORK EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant for Dr. Javier (Heavy Metal Tolerance *Basidiobolus* Fungi)

Department of Biology

Worcester, MA

January 2026 – Present

- Lead an independent project investigating heavy metal tolerance and stress responses in *Basidiobolus* fungi through growth assays across varying metal concentration gradients (eg. zinc, copper, cadmium, lead, etc)
- Designed and executed experimental protocols, including media preparation, metal stock solutions, fungal culturing, and quantitative analysis of mycelial growth

Clark Business Coordinator

School of Business - Entrepreneurship & Innovation

Worcester, MA

January 2025 – May 2026

- Coordinated weekly campus initiatives by managing logistics, vendor relationships, timelines, and on-site execution for School of Business programming for 40 vendors
- Supported strategic initiatives with the School of Business director, including drafting National Science Foundation (NSF) grant proposals and coordinating supporting documentation

Research Assistant for Dr. Nag (Cancer Therapeutics using Macrocyclic Peptides)

Department of Biochemistry

Worcester, MA

September 2024 – January 2026

- Reviewed, synthesised, and analysed experimental data from macrocyclic peptide research, contributing to evidence development across multiple concurrent lab projects in oncology drug discovery
- Collaborate with PhD researchers, as the sole undergraduate, to coordinate experimental workflows, track peptide synthesis progress, and document results across multiple development experiments
- Presented research findings at Clark Fest, a STEM symposium, translating complex biochemical data for a multidisciplinary audience of 200+ students and faculty

VOLUNTEERING / EXTRACURRICULAR EXPERIENCE

Shared Living Strategy Intern

Open Sky Community Services – Shared Living

Worcester, MA

September 2025 – December 2025

- Synthesised and analysed market research data on healthcare benefits, caregiver models, and stipend structures, presenting findings in strategic reports and materials to inform organisational decision-making
- Developed strategic internal and external engagement materials including a promotional video and caregiver outreach form, supporting uptake of the Shared Living programme among diverse client populations

Women's Tennis Varsity Athlete

Clark Athletics

Worcester, MA

January 2025 – Present

- Competed as an NCAA Division III varsity athlete, training six days per week including mandatory strength and conditioning, with two to three competitions weekly
- Represented the team in both singles and doubles formats as part of a 10-person roster, demonstrating adaptability and strong communication in high-pressure competitive environments.

ADDITIONAL

Awards: Donald J. Nelson Research Fellow (2025), US President's Education Award for Outstanding Academic Excellence (2022), Student Service Award for Leaders and Outstanding Contributions to Our Community (2022)

Technical Skills: Excel, PowerPoint, Word, Data Analysis

Certifications: Wall Street Prep, BCG – Venture & Biotech Venture, BCG – Strategy consulting, Fundamentals of Investing – SoFi, Intro to Negotiation – Yale University

Languages: Macedonian (native), English (fluent), Serbian (fluent), French (fluent), Spanish (basic)

Interests: Tennis, Travelling (Malta, Netherlands, Turkey), Hiking, Reading, Painting/Drawing